College Bound

ISSUES & TRENDS FOR THE COLLEGE ADMISSIONS ADVISOR

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Admissions Watch

More on the Class of 2029

Bradley's Three-Year Tracks. Bradley U. in Peoria, Illinois, enrolled 642 new freshmen and 150 transfer students, fewer than last year. Meanwhile, nationally, demographers are predicting a 15 percent decrease in college-age students between 2025 and 2029, caused by a decline in birth rates during the Great Recession of 2008.

"We've known the demographic shifts were coming," Angie Cooksy, vice president for enrollment management and communications, told the *Bradley Scout*. "What matters is how we respond, and I'm confident in the strategic actions Bradley has already taken and will continue to take to position ourselves for growth."

Bradley is hoping its small classes of about 17 students each and new three-year degree tracks across all five of its colleges will attract students who want to save time and money.

Florida State Apps Up 182 Percent in a Decade. Florida State U. in Tallahassee attracted more than 86,000 applications this spring, an increase of 182 percent in first-year applications over the past decade. FSU enrolled approximately 6,200 new students in its Class of 2029.

"We encourage students to consider things like major, finances, student life, campus culture, location and more when building their college list," Erin Verity, FSU director of first-year admission, told *USA Today*.

New C. Record. New College, a public liberal arts school in Sarasota, Florida, was refashioned from what was considered a progressive institution to the "Honors College of Florida," with a conservative bent, by Governor Ron DeSantis. It emphasizes "independent learning, critical thinking and interdisciplinary studies." This fall, New C. enrolled 900 students, the most in school history, with 300 new students for each of the last three years. New C. offers 50 undergraduate majors and boasts of a 10:1 student/faculty ratio.

Northeastern Tops 100,000 Apps. Northeastern U. in Boston received 105,283 applications for its Class of 2029 and matriculated 2,735 first-year students on its Boston campus, while 727 joined its Oakland campus and another 812 were London Scholars. Others began their study in New York City, France, Germany, Greece, the Czech Republic and elsewhere. Altogether, they came from 97 countries. What attracted them?

According to Satyajit Dattagupta, chief enrollment officer and special advisor to the university president, "Students and their families are laser-focused on return on investment. Northeastern answers that need better than any institution with its focus on academic excellence, groundbreaking research, global mobility and experiential learning."

Each year, Northeastern students participate in co-op programs with small start-ups and global conglomerates in 158 countries for six months at a time, and graduate with up to 18 months of work/learning experience. Over 90 percent of graduates find jobs in areas related to their majors.

Stony Brook's Quantum Future. Stony Brook U. (SUNY) on Long Island attracted 3,963 new students this fall to its Class of 2029. That includes 402 international students, fewer than last year. They were culled from about 64,200 applications, up by 8,360 over last year or about 15 percent and 64 percent since 2021.

SBU's acceptance rate is 48 percent. Over 80 percent went to high school somewhere in New York state, although out-of-state applications are increasing. Stony Brook's first-to-second year retention rate is 89.4 percent.

"We are constantly bringing in a new class

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Financial Matters

Colleges Facing Tough Economic Choices. An October 30 *Wall Street Journal* article noted that "Even before President Trump's federal funding cuts, many schools were already stretched by years of competitive spending. Their budget struggles are, in many cases, more than a decade in the making, and it's not just far-flung state universities or D-list private colleges suffering….

"In the years leading up to the pandemic, low interest rates fueled borrowing binges across higher education to build snazzy academic buildings and dorms…. Moody's Investors Service now rates the general outlook for higher-education bonds 'negative,' while Fitch Ratings deems the sector 'deteriorating.'"

The *Journal* profiled different universities, but focused on the U. of Chicago, where total debt has hit $5 billion. The article also outlined ways the U. of C. is addressing its problems.

New York Colleges Waive App Fee. In New York State, 130 colleges waived application fees during October to boost access and affordability. These included the State University of New York, the City University of New York and numerous private colleges and universities.

Three-Quarters of Cal High School Students Applied for Aid. The number of California high school students who applied for financial aid rose by 11 percent this year to nearly three-quarters of all students. According to the California Student Aid Commission, that amounted to around 340,000 students. The number was boosted after a

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Class of 2029

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that is more academically talented and ready to succeed in college," provost Carl Lejuez told the *Village Times Herald*.

Recently, New York Governor Kathy Hochul pledged $300 million to the university to support a Quantum Research and Innovation Hub.

Texas's All-Time High. The U. of Texas at Austin attracted 55,000 students including 9,900 freshmen, 7.5 percent more than last year selected from more than 90,000 applicants, 24.4 percent more than the previous cycle.

This fall, about 1.6 million students enrolled in Texas public and private colleges and universities, 4.7 percent more than last year and an all-time high, according to the Texas Higher Education Coordinating Board. Enrollment at private colleges jumped by 6.7 percent. ■

Financial Matters

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2021 state law required high schools ensure students complete the FAFSA.

Last year, the Commission did research into why parents still resist filling out the form and found that families are skeptical that aid is actually free. Yet California will spend about $2.9 billion in aid during the 2025-26 school year.

Room and Board Endanger Affordability. According to analysis by the Public Policy Institute of California, room & board are presenting affordability problems for California students. Already challenged by rising tuition (6 percent per year for the next five years at California State U.) financial aid for free tuition has only kept pace for half of students. Housing and tuition add another burden.

Rent in California is 50 percent above the national median. For Cal students, room and board often outpaces the cost of tuition. Food and off-campus housing for CSU students runs $18,198 a year, for UC students $15,149. About 48 percent of CSU aid students live off campus. At UC, the number is only 20 percent. Some students are receiving additional aid for these items through CalFresh and the Middle Class Scholarship program.

But overall, costs are still daunting for low-income CSU families who spend one quarter of their income on college costs, and low-income UC families who shell out one third of their income.

Smith Offers Tuition-Free Middle-Class Aid. Beginning next year, Smith C. in Massachusetts will provide tuition-free enrollment for both domestic and international students from families earning up to $150,000. The Next 150 Pledge is part of Smith's 150th anniversary celebration. ■

ENROLLMENT TRENDS

California State U. Enrollment Up 4,000. The California State U. System enrolled 4,000 more students in Fall 2025, but saw a dip in the number of out-of-state and international enrollees. The 22-campus system attracted about 465,000 students.

Harvard Enrolled Fewer Minority Students. Harvard C.'s Class of 2029 included fewer black and Latino students, the university reported. This fall, 11.5 percent of the class identified as African American, down from 14 percent last year and 18 percent in 2023, the last year before the Supreme Court struck down affirmative action in college admissions.

The number of Latinos in the new class fell from 16 percent last year to 11 percent. Meanwhile, Asian American enrollment increased to 41 percent of the class.

International students make up 15 percent of the Class of 2029, down from 16 percent last year. However, low-income students total about 21 percent of the class and 45 percent are attending tuition-free.

At Princeton U., black students make up only 5 percent of the Class of 2029, while Asian American enrollment rose to 27 percent.

Maine Community College Enrollment Rises. Fall enrollment rose 3 percent at Maine's community colleges from 15,366 to 15,833. Tuition and fees stand at $4,156 a year, the lowest in New England.

"This sustained enrollment growth is critical at a time when Maine's economy needs more skilled employees in a range of industries that we specifically target for high-quality, low-cost instruction, from construction to computer science," David Daigler, president of the Maine Community College System, told Seacoastonline.

North Carolina State Clears Path for C.C. Students. Students from all 58 community colleges in North Carolina are now eligible to enroll in N.C. State U. through its "Wolf Pack Connect" option.

"This is a game-changer for our students," Jeff Cox, president of the NC Community College System, told WNCN. "Now, with guaranteed admission to NC State, students across the state can start their journey close to home and know that a path to one of the nation's top research universities is waiting for them."

Ohio Enrollment, Gains and Losses. Enrollment at most Ohio public colleges is up this fall, while international enrollment is down.

- Bowling Green State U. enrolled 20,383 students, a 3.5 percent increase;
- Cleveland State U. enrolled 13,107 students, a 6.62 percent decrease;
- Miami U. enrolled 22,281 students, a 1 percent decrease;
- The Ohio State U. enrolled 67,255 students, a 0.5 percent increase;
- Ohio U. enrolled 30,682 students, a 3.6 percent increase;
- Shawnee State U. enrolled 3,483, a 7.69 percent increase;
- The U. of Akron enrolled 15,318 students, a 3.28 percent increase;
- The U. of Cincinnati enrolled 53,682 students, a 0.83 percent increase;
- The U. of Toledo enrolled 14,290 students, a 1.03 percent decrease;
- Wright State U. enrolled 11,924 students, a 0.86 percent increase;
- Youngstown State U. enrolled 12,240 students, a 2.1 percent increase.

Oklahoma Public Enrollment Up for Fifth Straight Year. Enrollment at Oklahoma's public colleges and universities grew by 6,100 students or 3.6 percent this fall, mostly due to an increase in first-time students. The U. of Oklahoma and Oklahoma State U. both recorded 4.7 enrollment growth. Community college enrollment edged up by 4.3 percent. The number of high school grads who went directly to college also increased, by 4.1 percent.

San Diego State U.'s Record. San Diego State U. and SDSU Imperial Valley enrollment this fall topped 40,000 students for the first time. Total enrollment climbed to 41,184, 4.6 percent higher than last year. The two campuses attracted more than 120,000 undergraduate and graduate applications.

"Each year, more students from across California and around the world choose SDSU because they see a community that will challenge them, support them and help them achieve their goals," said Stefan Hyman, associate vice president for enrollment.

South Dakota Technical Colleges See Growth. Enrollment in South Dakota's four technical colleges increased 5 percent this fall to 7,774 students who are registered full-time or in dual enrollment high school programs.

Enrollment Mixed Bag at SW Virginia Colleges and Universities. Several institutions grew, some remained "steady," while others declined, according to the *Cardinal News* which recently surveyed 14 Soutwest Virginia private and public four-year colleges and universities for data available as of Novemeber12. For example, those increasing:

Randolph C. set a second consecutive enrollment record this fall. The incoming freshman class of 273 topped last year's high of 266.

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The Counselor's Corner

Application Tips and Sources

Sophie Smith's Top Suggestions. The *New York Post* recently ran an article in which Sophie Smith, co-founder and CEO of College Contact, offered useful tips on writing essays. For example, "Don't rely on AI for college essays. Admissions officers can easily detect that kind of writing." And, "Find balance in essays, avoid sensationalism, keep it PG.

"Focus on stories that reveal curiosity, growth or character.... Authenticity doesn't mean baring your soul. It means showing judgment, maturity and a clear sense of who you're becoming."

CUNY's New Support Services. The City Colleges of New York welcomed 240,000 students this fall with new student support initiatives including "programs in AI and education, immigration assistance, easier transfer between colleges and renewed focus on student life."

Kentucky Redesigning Admission Process. The Kentucky Student Success Collaborative (KYSSC) released a plan to overhaul the admissions process at several state schools.

"The priorities we've identified," Lilly Massa McKinley, KYSSC executive director, told nkytribune.com, "will promote earlier and more frequent outreach to prospective undergraduates and increase transparency around college costs, financial aid awards, housing, credit transfer [including dual credits] and degree pathways."

Texas' First-Year Support. The number of first-generation students applying to Texas's 61 public colleges and universities has more than tripled over the last five years, according to *The Texas Tribune*. That led state colleges and universities to innovate with support systems.

About a third of Texas Tech undergraduates are first in their family to go to college. That's why TT set up a "residential learning community specifically for support of first-year students."

According to *The Hechinger Report*, the U. of Texas Rio Grande Valley and U. of North Texas Dallas offer mentoring programs via older students known as "trailblazers." Duane Williams, associate vice provost for student success and retention at Texas A & M, calls his strategy of mandatory support for students "inescapable engagement."

And, according to the Coalition for College's national registry, Texas also supports 36 nonprofits and community-based organizations that help high school students with college preparedness.

Reading for Pleasure Plummets. According to the *Financial Times,* data from the U.S. government's American Time Use Survey shows the proportion of people who read for pleasure on an average day fell from 28 percent in 2003 to 16 percent in 2023. That means any kind of reading done for enjoyment or purposes other than work or school. This included people reading news online, but not scrolling.

Time spent reading with children did not change significantly over two decades but was distressingly low. Although 21 percent of participants had a child under the age of nine, only 2 percent recorded reading with them.

"This is concerning, given that regular reading during childhood is a strong determinant of reading ability and engagement later in life," one of the researchers from the U. of Florida pointed out. "The low rates of reading with children may thus contribute to future declines in reading among adults."

Researchers also noted that reading helps "support mental health, empathy, creativity and life-long learning."

Brainfuse Partners with Ivy Tech and Northern Virginia C.C. Brainfuse for Student Success, an online academic support provider based in New York, is now working with 177,000 students at Ivy Tech C. C. in Indiana and at the six campuses of Northern Virginia C.C. For the past quarter century, Brainfuse has provided an assortment of live tutoring, writing support and study tools to help students succeed in and out of class.

YouTube Links

2025 Trends. Here's a YouTube.com link for a 36-minute conversation on "A Conversation with Parents: College Admissions Trends 2025" with Lisa Bleich, College Bound Mentors. (Not associated with collegeboundnews.com.)

See, https://youtube.com.

YouTube (14 minutes) with Erica Brozovsky of Study Hall, "How to Apply for College."

The TRUTH About College Admissions in 2026 (It's Not Getting Easier) with former Wharton School MBA Admissions Director Thomas Caleel. ■

COUNSELOR'S BOOKSHELF

A Problem of Fit: How the Complexity of College Pricing Hurts Students and Universities by economist Phillip Levine, U. of Chicago Press, ISBN-10: 0226818551. While at Wellesley C., Levin created MyinTuition, a net price calculator used by 70 universities.

Metrics That Matter: Counting What's Really Important to College Students by Zachary Bleemer, Mukul Kumar, Aashish Mehta, Chris Muellerleile and Christopher Newfield; Johns Hopkins Press, ISBN-10: 1421445735, $26.95 paper.

Paying for College, 2026; Princeton Review, Penguin/Random House; ISBN 978-0593-51878-6, $25.99. The book provides assistance on filling out the FAFSA.

Leading in the AI Era, a Chronical of Higher Education Print and Digital package; Chronical bookstore. It includes, "What more than 900 campus leaders, faculty and staff really think about AI's potential, and its perils."

The Best 391 Colleges, 2026 by Rob Frank, ed., Penguin/Random House; ISBN 978-0-593518298; $26.99.

For example, the book ranks "Professors Get High Marks," (Sarah Lawrence C. #1); "Best Classroom Experience," (Washington & Lee #1;) "Best Student Support Services," (Seton Hall U. #1); "Most Beautiful Campus," (U. of the South #1); "Most Politically Conservative Students, (Thomas Aquinas C. (CA) #1); "Most Politically Liberal Students," (Reed C. #1); "Most Politically Moderate Students, (U. of Richmond #1); and so forth.

"What If My Kid Can't Get in to His Dream School?" *U.S. News and World Report:* October 16 issue. ■

CURRICULUM CAPSULES

Brandeis Launches Four Schools. Brandeis U. in Massachusetts realigned and established four new schools that "integrate its graduate professional programs into its liberal arts curriculum… to connect rigorous academic learning with practical, career-focused applications."

The School of Arts, Humanities and Culture "explores how humans express, interpret and shape the world through language, literature, philosophy, the arts and culture." The School of Business and Economics "prepares students to lead in a global economy shaped by data, innovation and rapid change."

The School of Science, Engineering and Technology "powers scientific exploration and discovery through interdisciplinary programs, including a new engineering science major, hands-on scientific research and a distinctly liberal arts approach. And, the School of Social Sciences and Social Policy "examines how individuals, communities and systems interact—and how pressing social issues can be addressed through policy, research and civic engagement."

New England Adds Workforce Needs. The U. of New England announced five new academic programs aimed at meeting student demand and bolstering Maine's pressing needs including two undergraduate business majors in supply chain management and economics, a psychiatric mental health nurse practitioner master's degree program and undergraduate minors in gerontology and public history.

North Carolina's New Options. The U. of North Carolina introduced new programs including a B.S. in Community and Global Public Health that "prepares students to work in partnership with local and global communities to identify, assess and address health challenges while advancing health equity."

Also new, a M.A./Ph.D. program in African and African Diaspora Studies that offers "an innovative and interdisciplinary approach to graduate education that bridges the traditional divides between African studies and African American/diaspora studies."

Purdue Expands Indianapolis Campus. Purdue U., whose flagship campus of 58,000 students is in West Lafayette, is beginning its second year as sole operator of the former IU/PUI campus in Indianapolis, and is expanding offerings "rooted in science, technology, engineering and math," several in combination with local industries.

These include a radiopharmaceutical manufacturing graduate degree with SpectronRX; a sports engineering program to work with the local multi-billion-dollar sports industry; and a business and engineering program. Also, this academic year it launched a B.S. in actuarial science.

Next year, Purdue Indianapolis will add a B.S. in construction management technology, B.S. in hospitality and tourism management, B.S. in industrial engineering and a B.S. in multidisciplinary technology, among other options.

Rochester Designs New Offerings. The U. of Rochester in New York now offers a B.A. in Latin American, Caribbean and Latinx Studies, a Business Master's Pathway for its undergraduates, a M.S. in Aerospace Engineering, an online M.S. in Healthcare Data Science and AI, a M.S. in AI and Business, a Master's Direct Entry into Nursing Practice.

Saginaw Valley State U. Added Three Academic Programs. Beginning this fall, SVSU in Michigan introduced a bachelor's degree in economics and data. The curriculum includes coursework in economics, mathematics and computer science. It also premiered a new dual program that allows students to complete two master's degrees in health administration and public health, concurrently over three years. And it announced a nine-credit graduate certificate in workplace conflict management.

Xavier Introduces Eight New Majors, Minors and Certificates. This fall, Xavier U. in Cincinnati introduced eight new majors, minors and certificates in fields spanning the sciences, technology, business, health care, education, including programs focused on artificial intelligence, cybersecurity, genetics and speech-language pathology.

Computer Science Study Down. According to the National Student Clearinghouse Research Center report recently released, "enrollment in computer science dove significantly this fall."

Enrollment at graduate schools was down 15 percent while it was down 6 percent at two-year undergraduate institutions.

Meanwhile, "trade" majors were up between 8 to 10 percent at two-year institutions. These include engineering technologies as well as mechanic and repair technologies. Health majors increased 3 percent for graduate students and 10 percent for undergraduate two-year degrees. ■

New Veterinary Programs

Clemson's Inaugural Veterinary Class. Clemson U. in South Carolina got the go ahead from the American Veterinary Medical Association to begin accepting students while continuing to pursue full accreditation. Applications were through November 17 with the first class enrolling in Fall 2026.

Rowan Opens Vet School. Rowan U. in New Jersey is meeting the shortage of veterinarians in the state with its new Schreiber School for Veterinary Medicine. Previously, N.J. students had to go out-of-state to schools such as Cornell U., Ohio State or the U. of Pennsylvania to get necessary training.

"We have been waiting for this for a long time," Aparna Zama, undergraduate program director at Rutgers U. Department of Animal Sciences, told WHYY News. ■

Enrollment Trends

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Undergraduate enrollment hit 743, up from 703 last fall. Randolph attributes the increase to a new fall schedule, the *Cardinal News* reported.

The private university in *Lynchburg* also credits much of its growth to its scheduling model. Randolph students "take four courses per semester which are divided into two seven-week blocks." The college has 905 students between undergraduate and graduate programs and has a goal of about 1,200 overall.

Hollins C. in Roanoke added direct admissions to boost marketing. Hollins enrolled 676 undergraduate students this fall compared to 665 undergraduates last year. In 2024, it expanded scholarships. And in Fall 2026 Virginia students using the Common App may receive a notification offering them direct admission to Hollins.

Radford U. also began offering direct admission in 2023. Incoming students must have a GPA of 3.3 and a passing grade for algebra II. Undergraduate enrollment was 6,206 students, 40 more than last fall. Radford's most popular academic programs for bachelor's degrees include nursing, criminal justice and business administration.

Virginia Tech U. added about 500 undergraduate students over last year, for a total of 31,536. But Tech has plans to limit its enrollment growth to between 1 percent and 1.5 percent over the next four years.

Ferrum College reported that its incoming class of 38 students was its largest since 2018. ■

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